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THE BROOKLYN DAILY EAGLE

NEW YORK CITY, FRIDAY, SEPTEMBER 21, 1917.

MACHINE GUN COMPA[illegible], 14TH REGT., ENCAMPED AT SHEEPSHEAD BAY



Machine Gun Company, Fourteenth Regiment, at Sheepshead Bay: Bottom row, left to right—John Dempsey, Frank Cochran, Christopher Crosby, Corporal F. X. Coleman, Corporal Joseph E. Perkins, First Class Private William E. Pitt, George King, Thomas G. Nelson, Joseph H. Clarke, Samuel Wasson, Sigmund Loewenkopf, Salvatore Bonefede, Corporal George Tice, Frank O. Jensen, Corporal J. F. Cox, Robert Van Cott, Charles W. Corr, James Daly, Lou Kellis, Anthony Gilatti. Middle row—Charles H. Kissam, Harry Houghton, Arthur Stickney, Edwin Gilson, Joe Tucker, Musician Charles J. Quigley, Hubert Cornish, Edward Maloney, Musician Charles Breslin, Anthony Foglio, Joseph Clooney, Lawrence Hopps, Corporal Lathan, Sidney Peyser, William H. Feeley, John F. Barrett. Top row—Corporal Harry Lavin, Frank Hollohan, Corporal Israel, Mechanic J. Lester, Ed. H. Creighton, Sergeant P. S. Raleigh, Mechanic Charles Cozine, First Sergeant S. H. Gardner, Lieutenant Grover Cleaver, Captain Harry B. Harring, Lieutenant J. F. Curtis, William E. Greenings, Sergeant George W. Weldig, Harold Blauvelt, Sergeant E. Q. Greenips, Jr., Matthew Canavan, D. Atwell, Sergeant Benjamin F. Orth, Sergeant E. W. Spencer, Sergeant Thomas J. Wilson, Sergeant William J. Bailey, Charles Fleming, Sergeant S. Pivovar, Walter J. Abrams.

WALKS AND TALKS

By JULIUS CHAMBERS

Fallacy of "Free Ports" as a Defense Against Commercial War.

FORMER Ambassador Gerard has evolved an idea that is either aberrant folly or the most brilliant suggestion that has come from any American statesman or diplomat since the World's War began. In his "Recollections" of four years' German intrigue and chicanery, prior to and during the conflict, he seriously makes the suggestion that before peace is restored Congress should establish one or more "free ports" in this country! Doubtless, he has in mind the free towns of Bremen, Hamburg and Lonbeck, now parts of the German Empire.

Murray Hulbert, Representative of the Twenty-first Congressional District of New York, has introduced in the House a resolution directing the Secretary of the Treasury, the Secretary of War and the Secretary of Commerce to advise Congress as to the advisability of creating free ports within the established customs of the United States.

One wonders how many Americans comprehend what is meant by "free ports." I can suggest only one site for an American free port, and shall do so at the end of this Talk.

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Without going into the history of the idea's development from the Hanseatic League of the Twelfth Century, it may be stated that until the Nineteenth Century uniform customs tariffs did not generally exist throughout the various European countries, large or small. England had fixed uniform rates of duty on a few articles as early as 1660; free ports never existed there. Attempts had been made prior to the passage of the Subsidy Act (1660) to place Hull and Southampton on that footing, but they failed. The bonding system ultimately took the place of the "free town" idea. In November, 1534, an area of 150 acres at Copenhagen was declared to be a free port, with the admirable result that the Danish capital became the center of the Baltic trade.

Dalny, near Port Arthur, was a fine city built by Russia for a free port; but that dream vanished when Japan captured it, remodeled it Dairen and built a custom-house. Recently, Japan has announced that Dairen will be opened as a free port at the conclusion of the present war. Japanese statesmen are anxious to try the experiment.

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Of course, the three great examples of free cities are Hamburg, Bremen and Lonbeck, but, although these cities are all named in German official registers as "free," since 1888 only Hamburg has remained absolutely so. There, an area of 2,246 acres is exempt from customs duties and control. Bremerhaven, the port of Bremen, has a small area similarly regarded. Numerous ports of call are nominally "free ports," goods landed being subject only to city octroi (local duties); but they are always isolated places from which, if goods are re-shipped, duty will be exacted at the port of destination. Of these, Penang, Singapore, Hongkong and Aden are examples.

The United States adopted the bonding system, which serves all purposes of a free port, except that it does not benefit residents within the city having the bonded warehouses in which the merchandise is stored. New Orleans tried the experiment in 1896 by establishing a free wharf. I do not know whether the trial was satisfactory or not.

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Benefits to the local population within the "free" zone were unquestioned. Such privileges developed mighty cities, as in the case of Hamburg; but one doubts whether, for example, if Greater New York were made a free port tomorrow we, the inhabitants, would reap any benefit from abolition of duties.

A combination of traders exists, apparently, capable of exacting whatever prices they decree! A beneficent Congress, years ago, removed all import duties upon tea and coffee, "because they were in the poor man's dinner pail," but the prices of these two necessities of homely life have been screwed up until they are nearly as high as during the Civil War, when our clipper ships were chased from the seas by Confederate cruisers and a stiff duty was laid upon tea and coffee.

* * *

If the free port idea is tried, it should be at some small city on the coast—preferably a factory town; but I fear it will be a stone wall would have to be built around the city (for it would assuredly grow into one) to discourage the fine art of smuggling as carried on in comic operas and in some not so comic—"Carmen," for example.

It is not generally known, but millions of dollars worth of foreign merchandise are shipped under bond right through this city to Chicago, St. Louis and other large Western cities, warehoused therein and the duties finally paid there instead of at New York, which received all port charges and benefits.

Practically, Chicago became a port of entry under this bonding system. So far as Chicago was concerned, New York became "a free city"!

The recent development of vast warehouse systems in Brooklyn and on the New Jersey flats has had notable effect in detaining foreign goods here until their owners have need of them and desire to take them out of bond by paying the duties.

The theory is that the Government is in no hurry for its taxes, while the merchant has use for his money every hour.

* * *

If the hope of Representative Hulbert is that our foreign trade can be built up by increasing importations, he is barking up the wrong tree. What the people of the United States want, when this foreign slaughter is ended, is to sell the rest of the world our goods and grains, sending them abroad in American ships and receiving for them, principally, cash in payment!

NEVER AGAIN MUST OUR BALANCE OF IMPORTS EXCEED THAT OF EXPORTS!

Such ought to be the policy of this Government and the spirit of the American people.

* * *

If this war has done nothing else to awaken the American soul, it has aroused to every man, woman and child (not under restraint) that the United States can feed, clothe and educate its people without the assistance of the rest of the world! Within our borders everything necessary for our happiness and well-being can be raised or mined. I should probably except rubber for our automobile tires, all the world is under obligations to Brazil and the Congo Free State for that necessity of modern life. I will admit the exception until some American can cheapens celluloid to a point at which it can be substituted for rubber. I can remember, when in college studying mineralogy, to have been allowed by our professor of chemistry to handle a strip of aluminum about five inches long, three wide and no thicker than the cover of a dictionary, and to have been told it was valued at $2,500! Today that same metal is so cheaply produced that airships and steamships are made thereof. It is cheaper than copper, owing to its lightness. The piece of white metal I was shown as a curiosity did not weigh more than four ounces, and aluminum is literally "as cheap as dirt," meaning clay. Rubber, likewise, is bound to be supplanted by something that will be found in this country.

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The American people do not want any free ports; but the numskull who denounced the Hulbert resolution as "a free trade measure" didn't know what he was talking about.

It would be a free trade experiment so far as the people dwelling within the free zone were concerned; but, as I explained, tradesmen who got their foreign goods without payment of duty would see to it that their customers were the real beneficiaries of the experiment. They would mark their prices right up to those of the cities outside the free zone. There would become a case of "Dress out!"

Germany strenuously maintained the free zone at Hamburg, although the Empire had a protective tariff higher in some features than that which the American people endured for a generation in order to enrich the iron, sugar and cotton barons!

Germany made a thousand sacrifices for the sake of building up a great foreign trade. The work was successfully done. When the Prussian Wilhelm II forced this war upon his commercial rivals, Germany was doing the second largest carrying trade on the Seven Seas. A fleet of her steel leviathans was entering and leaving this harbor every week! Her ships were to be encountered in Japan and the South seas.

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German customs officials watched the cargoes at Hamburg and Bremerhaven with keen eyes, but did not interfere. When Copenhagen opened a free zone Germany promptly retaliated by giving to Stettin and Danzig similar facilities and privileges. That gave to the Danes a serious jolt.

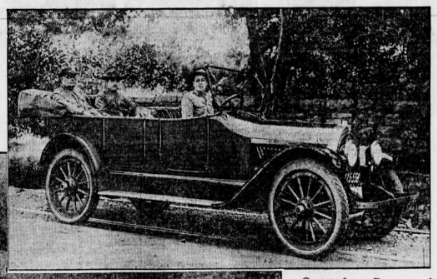
Free ports are intended to become great distributing centers, without in any manner affecting the amounts of revenue collected by the home or general government.

I believe it would be an excellent idea to convert St. Thomas, which we have recently acquired with the other foolish Virgins, into a free port. The United States could conduct all the bonding and transference of goods there. Vast warehouses could be built and the tendency would be to create a winter resort in the tropic of the first magnitude.

The allotment of Jamaica rum at a nominal price and French brandy free of duty would add a new realm to mint julep land and extend its fame as far as the Mississippi.

Excuse me, Mr. Hulbert, but if you want a free port, try St. Thomas.

Veteran Artillerymen on Guard Duty





Tents of Brooklyn men of the Veteran Artillery Corps on outpost duty "somewhere in New York State."

Captain Louis Praeger and Lieutenant William L. Sayers, Fifth Battery, Brooklyn, of the Veteran Artillery Corps on a tour of inspection.

Trench Practice in Texas



How Brooklyn boys are learning the art of trench digging is shown in this picture sent by William Klein, Co. B, 57th Infantry, from Leon Springs, Texas.

Soldier Boys of 57th in Boxing Match



In thanking the Sporting Editor of The Eagle for a set of boxing gloves, one of the boys of the Fifty-seventh Infantry writes:

"The boys are delighted and the gloves are the talk of the company. I've shown them to the Y. M. C. A. director and he thought them fine. You know The Eagle can always be found in any of the Y's here, and I always see it to see how things are going on 2,500 miles from home."

All Swell Folks.

The lovely and elegant home of that crown prince of hospitality, the big hearted and noble souled Ab Wever, was a radiant scene of enchanting loveliness, for Cupid had brought one of his finest offerings to the court of Hymen, for the lovable Miss Maude, the beautiful daughter of Mr. Weaver and his refined and most excellent wife, who is a lady of rarest charms and sweetest graces, dedicated her life's ministry to Dr. James E. Hobgood, the brilliant and gifted and talented son of that ripe scholar and renowned educator, the learned Professor Hobgood, the very able and successful president of the Oxford Female College.—Charlotte (Ky.) Chronicle.

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There may be greater demands for husbands after the war than ever. But husbands are used to demands.

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No one ever flew very high by flying off the handle.

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Some people's only ambition is not to need any ambition.

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If half the people don't know how the other half live, it isn't because they don't watch them moving in.

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The best way of getting a thing is to go after it, and the worst way is to go after it is too late.

* * *

Determination and application will accomplish anything in life except opening a car window.

* * *

When things have reached the point where friend wife is packing up to go home to mother, friend husband is usually glad to agree to a "status quo ante bellum."

TIPPERARY COMES TO BAGDAD.

Oh, they shook their magic carpet, an'
they made a 'sillish dust,
An' their slimy incantations, an' their
crystal globes went bust,
An' they sang their bloomin' chanties,
an' they banged their foolish
bells,
But we swivied we could get there,
spite o' all their cranky 'ells!
So we up wi' "Tipperary," an' we
pounded 'em like grain,
An' th' dust was like a blanket—
thought I'd never see again!
An' I kinder did regret it, for I'd fixed
my mind t' see
That land o' silly 'arems, and queer
kings, that lived t' apres!
Well, when we got inside it, I'd 'a'
never knowed it! Say—
Just a low-down, dirty 'amlet, where
no Britisher'd stay!
An' I wonder, wi' their magic, if they'd
changed it—d'ye see?
For I know this ain't the Bagdad
where o' Haroun use' t' be!
—Theda Kenyon in Everybody's Magazine.

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